

Lures & Baits

Choose by job

ChatGPT edition

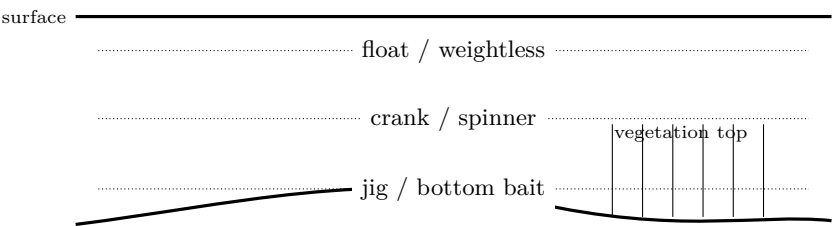
BAIT IS REGULATED

Inspect, remove, and drain before transport. Do not move live fish away from a waterbody. Put unwanted bait in trash and obey current source, water, and transport rules. Secure every exposed hook in storage.

Start with the job, not the brand

Tool	Job	Start here	First adjustment
Small jig	Depth contact; compact prey	Breaks, saddle, panfish or walleye search	Change weight to restore feel.
Slip bobber + legal bait	Hold exact depth	Vegetation edges and flats	Move stop in 1-ft steps.
Straight soft worm	Slow bass fall	Sparse cover and clear shelf edges	Weightless, then minimally weighted.
Weedless plastic	Enter vegetation	West Pine shelf; North flats	Add only enough weight to penetrate.
Crankbait	Cover a depth band	Hard edges with safe clearance	Running depth first, then speed.
Spinner / spoon	Flash and vibration	Weed lanes and active pike water	Add a bite-resistant leader when warranted.
Live minnow	Natural movement	Jig, float, or lawful predator rig	Keep lively; verify source and transport law.
Leech / crawler	Slow natural bait	Float or bottom rig	Downsize hook and use only what can be presented responsibly.

Depth-band picture



Intermediate question: Which band did the lure actually occupy? A nominal “deep” lure that fouls on weeds may spend no useful time at depth.

Live bait begins with a legal chain

1. **Before buying or collecting, verify.** Check the current Wisconsin DNR bait rules for the source, species, waterbody, transport route, season, and whether unused bait or water may leave the site. Keep the receipt or other required source evidence with the bait.
2. **At transfer, identify.** Reject unknown fish, mixed accidental species, visibly diseased bait, and containers with plants, mud, snails, or other hitchhikers. “Minnow” is not an identification.
3. **At the launch, separate water from permission.** Water carried from a dealer, home, or another waterbody can be regulated differently from the bait itself. Recheck before adding, exchanging, draining, or transporting any water.
4. **At departure, decide before pouring.** Never release unused bait, plants, animals, or container water into the lake or on the shoreline. Follow the current lawful disposal and transport route; when uncertain, seal it and ask rather than improvise.

NO LIVE-FISH ASSUMPTION SURVIVES THE TRIP

A bait that was lawful to possess may not be lawful to move away from a water, reuse elsewhere, or transport in water. The live DNR rule and posted direction beat this printed guide.

Store for the bait, not for convenience

Bait	Container and temperature	Check and correction
Live minnow	Clean insulated container; cool, stable water; loose secure lid; working aeration where needed	Watch swimming, crowding, gulping, temperature, and dead bait. Shade the container; exchange water only when lawful and temperature-compatible; remove dead bait promptly.
Nightcrawler	Ventilated escape-resistant box; cool, dark, damp commercial or clean bedding, never flooded	A healthy crawler is cool, moist, and responsive. Discard sour bedding and dead crawlers in trash; do not add lake soil or plants.
Leech	Escape-resistant smooth container; cool clean water; shaded	Confirm attachment and swimming response. Avoid hot decks, direct sun, crowding, and large sudden temperature changes. Handle with wet fingers.

Transport check

Container upright and restrained; lid ventilates without spilling; aerator, spare power, shade, and temperature plan work; receipt/source record and current rule are available; disposal container is ready.

Hook once, preserve function



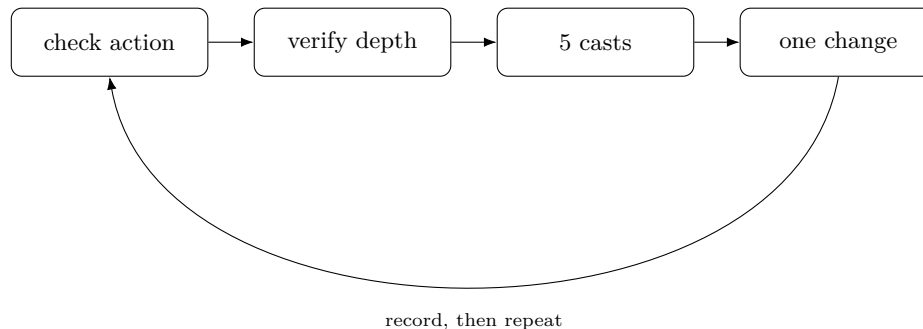
Bait	Deliberate hook path	Verify before the cast
Minnow	For a slow pull or jig, a shallow lip hook can enter the lower lip and exit the upper lip; other lawful presentations may call for a shallow back or tail placement. Avoid eyes, skull, spine, deep body cavity, and gills.	Mouth is not clamped by an oversized hook; bait stays upright, swims, and does not spin during a beside-boat pull. Replace a dead or badly injured bait lawfully.
Nightcrawler	Pierce once or twice near one end; leave most of the crawler free. For a small pan-fish bait, use a short segment rather than hiding an oversized hook in a ball.	Point and gap remain exposed; crawler hangs rather than corkscrews; cast force will not tear it immediately.
Leech	Identify the broad rear sucker and pass a small hook shallowly through that sucker, not through the narrow head.	Leech can extend and swim; hook gap is open; body is not wrapped around leader or weight.

Six-second bait verification

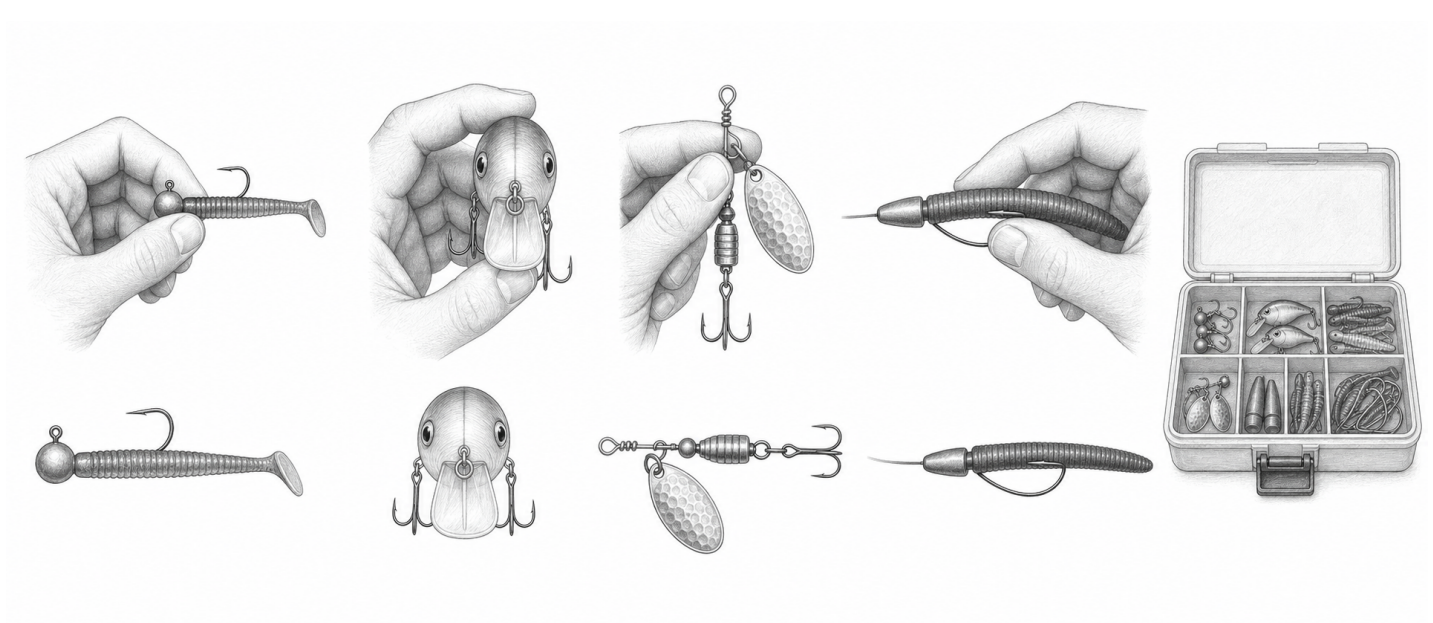
1. Wet the holding hand; touch bait briefly and gently.
2. Confirm species/source and that the chosen bait is alive enough to perform the intended job.
3. Match hook wire and gap to bait size; expose the point.
4. Pull beside the boat: upright, moving, not spinning, not fouled.
5. After every miss, weed contact, or hard cast, inspect position and injury.
6. Stop using bait that cannot be presented humanely, effectively, and lawfully; dispose of it by the verified route.

Tune one presentation

1. **Verify action beside the boat.** The lure runs upright; soft plastic is straight; bait can move; hook point is clear.
2. **Establish depth.** Count down a jig, measure the bobber stop, or confirm bottom contact. Record the number.
3. **Make five comparable casts.** Same lane, distance, speed, and pause. Note weed, bottom, bite, or clean water.
4. **Change one variable.** Depth by 1 ft, jig weight one step, or retrieve from steady to stop-and-go. Repeat.



Inspect artificial bait before tuning it



Artificial	Pass condition
Jig + soft plastic	Body centered on the shank, not bunched or split; tail free; point and gap clear; head/eye and knot undamaged.
Crankbait	Line tie and bill straight; body and hooks free of cracks, weeds, and line; split rings close; bait tracks upright beside the boat.
Spinner / spoon	Shaft and blade unbent; blade turns at useful speed; rings, swivel, leader, and hook intact; lure does not roll uncontrollably.
Weedless soft bait	Body straight; point lightly skin-hooked or aligned with the hook channel; enough gap remains to clear the plastic; weight and knot seat correctly.

Measurements that transfer

Record	How to verify
Float depth	Measure stop to hook; subtract the suspended weight/hook drop if precision matters.
Jig fall	Count seconds to first bottom touch in known depth; repeat with taut and semi-slack line.
Crank clearance	Rod tip and retrieve keep periodic bottom/weed ticks without continuous fouling.
Weed penetration	Weight enters the canopy yet comes back with the hook point clear often enough to fish efficiently.

Troubleshooting

Symptom	Corrective sequence
Lure spins	Check bent shaft, crooked plastic, fouled hook, and excessive speed beside the boat before casting again.
No bottom feel	Use thinner line or one weight step heavier; shorten cast; verify in known depth.
Every cast fouls	Inspect the actual weed-top depth; fish 1 ft above it, parallel the edge, or switch to a weedless geometry.
Live bait dies quickly	Correct temperature, oxygen, crowding, and handling; verify aeration and actual water temperature; discard lawfully rather than moving it or its water to another waterbody.
One short strike	Inspect and sharpen/replace hook; do not instantly change three variables. Repeat the verified lane first.

Presentation passes when

It enters the intended depth band, remains correctly rigged, returns free of hidden fouling, and can be repeated within the same cast lane. Only then does a bite or no-bite compare meaningfully.

Source basis: Wisconsin DNR Hook Your Catch; Fishing for Dinner; Boat Transportation and Bait Laws; current DNR bait and aquatic-invasive-species rules must be checked for the exact source, destination, and date.

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